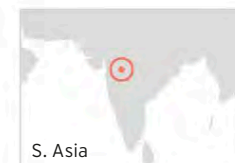


Ajanta Caves

A treasure trove of paintings and sculptures that are among the finest examples of Buddhist art



Despite their Hindu faith, the Gupta kings of ancient India were tolerant of other religions. Their period of rule (c.320–550 CE) saw a tremendous flourishing of philosophy, the sciences, art, and architecture. This included the creation of a number of significant early Buddhist sculptures and sites, the most famous of which are arguably the magnificent caves at Ajanta in western India.

Buddhist art

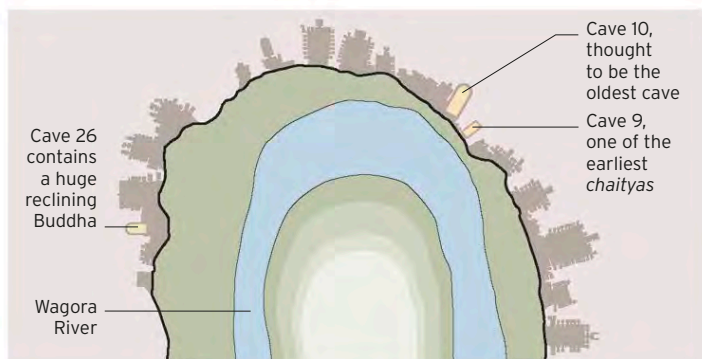
The 29 Buddhist cave temples and monasteries in Ajanta were carved from a basalt hillside intermittently between the 2nd century BCE and the 7th century CE. They contain sophisticated

examples of Buddhist sacred art, including impressive representations of the Buddha and breathtaking paintings and murals that tell his life story, often in a rich, intense palette. It is generally believed that Cave 10 is the earliest cave sanctuary in the complex; it contains a *chaitya*—a prayer hall with a stupa (dome-shaped shrine) at one end. But most of the caves at Ajanta were for monastic residence and often featured an elaborate facade, with a central courtyard and adjoining cells.

The caves were abandoned for centuries. In 1819, a British hunting party stumbled upon them by chance—they soon became the subject of increasing global interest.

PHASES OF EXCAVATION

Ajanta's caves are laid out in an immense arc that follows the path of the Wagora River. Evidence suggests they were excavated in two main phases: an early phase around the 1st and 2nd centuries BCE; and a later phase, when most of the caves were dug, during the peak of India's golden age under Gupta rule, in the 5th century CE.



△ ANCIENT MURAL

This detail from a 5th-century CE mural in Cave 1 at Ajanta illustrates an episode from the *Jataka* tales—stories about the previous lives of the Buddha.

▷ ROCK-CUT ARCHITECTURE

Two magnificent, robust, and highly ornamented rock-cut pillars at Cave 26 testify to the astonishing artistic skill and craftsmanship of ancient India.

